

PACE

How fast or slow a text feels to read



1 What is it?

Pace

Pace is how **fast or slow** a piece of writing feels to move through — controlled by sentence length, paragraph length, action, and description.

short sentences = fast | long sentences = slow

2 See it in action

Fast pace

He ran. He fell. He got up. Short, sharp sentences speed the action up.

Slow pace

A long, flowing sentence full of gentle description slows the reader right down.

Building tension

Sentences get shorter and shorter as danger approaches, quickening the pulse.

A sudden pause

After frantic action, one short, still sentence can bring everything to a halt.



You got this!

Count the **average sentence length** in a passage — a sudden run of short sentences almost always signals a pace change worth commenting on.

FUN FACT

Pace and sentence length are so closely linked that examiners specifically look for writers who vary their sentence length ON PURPOSE — an unbroken string of long sentences (or short ones) is usually a sign of weaker writing.

3 Why writers use it

Pace helps writers: match the rhythm of the writing to the emotion of the scene — fast pace for action and panic, slow pace for calm reflection or building dread.

Pace works on the reader almost physically — short punchy sentences make your eyes (and heart rate) speed up, while long winding ones naturally slow your reading down.

4 Where you'll spot it

Action & thriller writing

Chase scenes are built from short, breathless sentences to keep the reader's pulse racing.

Nature & travel writing

Long, flowing sentences slow the reader down to match a peaceful, descriptive mood.



Watch out!

Pace isn't only about sentence length — paragraph length, the amount of dialogue vs description, and even punctuation (lots of full stops vs flowing commas) all affect how fast a text feels.



Good spot!

Ask what **emotion** the pace is creating — fast pace often means panic or excitement, slow pace often means calm or dread building.

5 Quick recap

How fast/slow a text feels

Controlled by sentence length

Matches the mood of a scene



Keep going!

Try rewriting one calm sentence as five short, urgent ones — read both versions aloud and feel how differently they land.